

STAY BARTERS

THE PLAY BOOK

*Build a professional website for a place.
Get the stay for free.*

Steps · Stack · Prompts · Tips · May 2026

THE STEPS

#	PHASE	WHEN
1	Find a place with a real story but no website	Before booking
2	Pitch the trade — stay for a website	WhatsApp or in-person
3	Interview the owner, photograph the property	Day 1–2 of stay
4	Build the site with Claude Code (vibe code it)	During or after stay
5	Buy domain, deploy to GitHub Pages, handoff	Within a week

Good candidates: On Airbnb but no standalone site. Unique story — farm, lake, family-run. Owner communicates personally. Not a resort.

THE PITCH

"I build websites for places I love. I'd like to trade — I'll build you a professional website that gets you direct bookings (no Airbnb commission), in exchange for [X nights]. You keep everything: the code, the domain, all of it."

What they get: 4-page site · GitHub repo they own · custom domain (first year on you, ~\$10–20) · handoff guide so they can update it themselves.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

ORIGIN STORY

- How did you come to build this?
- What was here before?
- What changed along the way?

WHAT MAKES IT SPECIAL

- What do guests say when they leave?
- What can't they get anywhere else nearby?
- What do you want them to feel on arrival?

PRACTICAL INFO

- What's included? (breakfast, transfers?)
- Check-in / check-out times?
- Activities on-site + nearby?

BOOKING

- WhatsApp number (international format)?
- Preferred booking message?
- Minimum stay? Seasonal pricing?

HONEST EXPECTATIONS

- What should guests know before arriving?
- Who is this place *not* for?

REVIEWS + SOCIAL

- On Airbnb/TripAdvisor? Star rating?
- Can I use quotes from your reviews?
- Instagram or Facebook?

PHOTOGRAPHY

Shoot across the stay, not all at once. Golden hour (6–8am, 4–6pm) is mandatory for outdoor shots.

MUST-HAVES

- **Hero** — full property, distance, golden hour
- **Setting** — lake, garden, nature, atmosphere
- **Exterior** — building + entrance + veranda
- **Room** — from doorway (zoomed out), bed, unique feature
- **Bathroom** — full shot + feature if unusual

STORY SHOTS

- **Host** — candid, doing something, not posed
- **Food** — full breakfast spread + close-up of local dish
- **Activities** — kayak, safari, bikes (1–2 per activity)
- **Details** — fruit on tree, textures, morning light

TECHNICAL

- Landscape for heroes + grids
- Portrait for bathroom + room detail
- No harsh noon sun
- Natural colors — just lift shadows
- Optimize to 200–400KB (squoosh.app)

STACK

LAYER	CHOICE	WHY
Code	Vanilla HTML/CSS/JS — no framework	No build step. Owner can edit directly.
Fonts	Cormorant Garamond + Inter (Google Fonts)	Boutique editorial feel
Hosting	GitHub Pages	Free, HTTPS auto-provisioned
Domain	Namecheap / Cloudflare / local registrar	~\$10–20/yr. First year on you.
Booking	WhatsApp wa.me/ pre-fill link	Zero integration — one tap to inquire
Reviews	Static HTML — copy from Airbnb/TripAdvisor	No widget, no dependency

4-PAGE MODEL

PAGE	WHAT'S ON IT
index.html — Home	Hero · welcome · host intro · rooms teaser · setting · activities · food · reviews · map + contact
rooms.html — The Room	Full-width photo slider · specs · amenities · honest note · book CTA
place.html — The Setting	Hero · photo grids · nature · activities · food carousel · book CTA
story.html — Our Story	3-act narrative: Before → Crisis → Now. Pull quote. "See the rooms" bridge.

DNS RECORDS (GITHUB PAGES)

```
A      @      185.199.108.153
A      @      185.199.109.153
A      @      185.199.110.153
A      @      185.199.111.153
CNAME  www    [username].github.io
```

CLAUDE PROMPTS

Use Claude Code to vibe code the site. These prompts build the full thing from scratch.

1. KICK OFF THE BUILD

```
Build a 4-page static website for [PLACE NAME] — a [brief description, e.g. "fruit farm with lakeside cottages in Sri Lanka"].

Stack: pure HTML/CSS/vanilla JS, no framework, no build step.
Fonts: Cormorant Garamond (display) + Inter (body) via Google Fonts.
Colors: warm linen background #f0ede4, deep [green/terracotta/navy] #1b3826 for CTAs and footer, near-black #18180f text.

Pages: index.html (homepage), rooms.html (accommodation), place.html (the setting), story.html (owner story).

WhatsApp number: [NUMBER in international format, no +]
Booking message: "Hi [Name], I found your place online and I'd love to book a stay. Could you tell me about availability?"

Put a floating WhatsApp button (fixed bottom-right) and a "Book Direct" nav button on every page.
```

2. FILL IN THE CONTENT

```
Here's the content for each section. Fill in all placeholders:

Owner: [NAME]. Story: [paste interview notes — origin, crisis, turning point, now].
What makes it special: [key quotes from owner].
What's included: [list].
Honest note for rooms page: "[e.g. Cold water showers. Nature is very close. Not a resort.]"
Reviews: [paste 5-6 real quotes from Airbnb/TripAdvisor with author name and country].
Location for map embed: [address or coordinates].
Activities nearby: [list with distances].
```

3. PLACE THE PHOTOS

```
Photos are in /photos/. Place them as follows:
- Hero image: [filename]
- Homepage welcome section: [filename]
- Host photo: [filename]
- Rooms teaser main (veranda/exterior): [filename]
- Rooms teaser side top (bed): [filename]
- Rooms teaser side bottom (bathroom): [filename]
- Room slider: [list 8-12 filenames]
- Food carousel: [list 4-6 filenames]

Add loading="lazy" to all images. Optimize with background: #e8e2d6 as placeholder.
```

4. DEPLOY

```
Create a CNAME file with one line: [domain.com]
Push to GitHub. Repo name: [property-slug].
Enable GitHub Pages: Settings → Pages → main / root.
Then walk me through the DNS records to add at [registrar name].
```

TIPS

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- **Get the real story.** Owner's own words — especially the crisis/turning-point chapter — is your best copy. Never write generic "welcome to our beautiful property."
- **WhatsApp pre-fills convert.** Write the booking message for them. URL-encode it. One tap to inquire. Put it everywhere: floating button, nav, dark footer on every page.
- **Honest expectations build trust.** Put the "cold showers / no restaurant / nature is close" note directly on the rooms page. It pre-qualifies and reduces disappointment.
- **Story page is the secret weapon.** Before → crisis → now. Guests who read it become bookers. Don't skip it.
- **Every teaser photo must answer a real question.** "What does the room look like? What's the setting?" A close-up of a door handle answers nothing. Use exterior shots, beds, landscape.
- **Country-code domains add credibility.** .lk, .co.il, .co.ke — cheap and local. Check the local registrar.
- **Reviews need attribution.** "— Momoyo, Japan" makes a quote credible. "— Guest" does not.